SAMURAI WEAPONS

Samurai swords were manufactured by a complex process to create a blade of outstanding strength and cutting power. Fighting without a shield, the samurai held the sword two-handed, using his weapon for defence and attack. He blocked enemy blows with the face or back of the sword, which were tempered for resilience and strength. Standing square-on to his opponent, he attacked with a downward slash of the brittle, curved, cutting edge, tempered for extreme hardness.

Katana
In the Edo period, the longer sword *(katana)* was worn exclusively by samurai, whereas the *wakazashi* could be carried by merchants and by townsmen. In combat samurai typically held the *katana* in a two-handed grip, for which the *tsuka* (hilt) allows plenty of room.

Yari
The *yari* was a straight-headed spear. They measured anywhere from 1m (3ft) to 6m (20ft). The longer versions were called *omi no yari* while the shorter ones were known as *mochi* or *tae yari*. The longest versions were carried by foot troops, while samurai usually carried the shorter versions.

TANTO

Mosaic decoration on handle

Tsuba (handguard)

Seppa (spacer)

Hole for *kogatana* (small blade)

Hole for *kogai* (skewer)

Hole for *tang* (portion of blade within the handle)

Tsuba and seppa
The metal guard, or *tsuba*, had a central hole for the tang, flanked by holes for the *kogatana* and *kogai*. Copper spacers (*seppa*) fitted on each side of the guard. *Tsuba* were decorated with gold or silver inlay.

Sheathed katana
The samurai used the softer back edge of the *katana* to parry blows, because the razor-sharp cutting edge was so hard it would chip or shatter if struck by another samurai's sword edge.

Mekugi joins hilt to tang of the blade

Saya (scabbard)

Yakiba (hardened edge)